

Episode 87: Once Upon a Time... (51) Creating Colours! *COO's* Special New Paint Colours Appear!

Since last weekend, a friend has been travelling overseas - she went to New York! Before her departure, I was helping her with travel arrangements, camera matters, various Manhattan things, and wow, how convenient! Long live the Internet!

"Well, let's take a look, shall we?"

We connected to Google Maps. We could see New York, Manhattan's cityscape in real satellite photos.

"Here's Times Square, and this is Broadway. Going all the way down, look, here's Wall Street, and this is 'Ground Zero.' And going a bit offshore, look, there's the 'Statue of Liberty,'" - that sort of thing.

And then there's that "Street View"! Manhattan is almost entirely covered, and clicking along the streets as you proceed feels like you're actually there.

I've been to New York about three times, but that was over 10 years ago. Back then, the Internet was just starting to spread, and it was the era of finally managing to connect to the net using hotel room phone lines with great difficulty.

Come to think of it, back then there was a fixed camera in Times Square that showed Times Square in real time, and I used to enjoy watching that footage (laughs).

Now, even modest New York hotels have broadband connections in each room, plus wireless LAN. Man, ten years makes a decade. I'd like to go take some photos soon too, with distant eyes...

Now then.

Resuming the long-interrupted *Coo: Far From Home* (Coo 遠い海から来たクー) old stories (laughs).

Storyboard work progressed, and character final designs kept appearing one after another. Which meant it was finally time for "colours." As I wrote before, I was a huge fan of the original novel, and I had my own images of protagonist Yosuke and Tetsuro father and son, as well as Cathy and Tony. I applied these vague, formless images in my head to the characters Okura-san had drawn.

And it was perfect!

As a fan of the original work, what I had been hoping was "I hope it's not too childish artwork." But the Yosuke that Okura-san drew was not a "child" but a "boy." Tetsuro and Cathy were also solid-lined, proper "adult" characters.

"This is it!" I remember joyfully doing the first colour direction for colour samples.

The human characters seemed like they'd translate fairly smoothly into forms (colours), but the colour of the true protagonist "Coo" wouldn't be decided. Or rather, "what colour would a baby plesiosaur be in the first place?" We had reached that fundamental question.

Enter the so-called "dinosaur picture books." While dinosaur figures were drawn with wonderful brushwork and vivid life, frankly speaking, these were only imaginary colours. So they weren't very helpful as reference. "Well, anyway, let's try painting something," I decided, and started making several colour samples as I thought of them.

However, there was one problem here. Yes, the paint problem.

As I've written several times before, Toei Animation (東映動画) at the time used STAC paints to make works, and with very few colours. COO was a theatrical work, so in addition to TV series paint (about 120 colours), theatrical "X paints" (about 70 colours) could be used, but honestly that wasn't nearly enough.

So I had the company negotiate, and as a "special exception," we got permission to also use "A-number paints" (about 80 colours) that were made for American co-productions.

However, these "X" paints and "A" paints were actually problematic - they were paints that had been added haphazardly during *Yamato*-era theatrical works and co-productions, so they weren't proper colour gradations. But you can't make something from nothing. I struggled with colour charts anyway and somehow assembled colour tones close to my image.

I managed to get through human characters with colour balance, creating atmospheric results, but "Coo" remained difficult and I hit a wall.

"I wonder? My impression is that it should be a bit brighter, but not this whitish, and not grey either, something more slippery feeling," said Director Imazawa. I'd made colour samples in countless subtle combinations - I'd lost count - but ah, it was still a bit different from the director's impression. I wasn't satisfied either, naturally. But we were out of paints, out of colours.

"Then let's make them."

That was a comment from production staff member Kaburaki-san.

"If we absolutely don't have them, let's have the paint company make them. This is such a big work, let's have them made."

If we don't have sleeves, let's first make those sleeves. Thus we reached the groundbreaking development of ordering special new paint colours exclusively for COO from STAC.

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